protection & cages

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44363539.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra is trying to be a better person, but some days her old mentality creeps up on her, sharp words on her tongue and an instinct to lash out before she gets hurt doing it's best to ruin her friendships. She doesnt want to be that person anymore, so she retreats away from the people that her brain tells her hate her. Adora goes after her. f Catra were in the kind of mental space to know that she's loved, she would have realized that was a given.
(Or, a bad day after it all, and how it gets better)

Notes

Did y'all enjoy all the fluff in the last fic? Well, sorry. Imean, it's not angst, but it's not daisies either.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra was supposed to go to the Fright Zone to work on the rebuilding project today.

Supposed to.

Adora got up before her, left a note and told Melog where she was going so Catra wouldnt panic, and went for a run. She couldnt go back to sleep or lay idle any longer. She has a lot to do, everybody does as they work on building a future now the war is over, but she's used to fighting constantly and always having to be on edge, so peace is making her a little restless. When she came back it was time for breakfast. Catra was quiet, but Adora assumed she was just tired because she had to cajole her out of bed. After breakfast, they parted ways. Adora was supposed to go plan areas to sweep to make sure everybody had gotten the memo that the fighting is *over*. That only lasted until Scorpia's face popped up on the tracker pad she was using.

Adora returns to their bedroom, anxiety thrumming in her chest. She eases the door open cautiously. Part of her worry instantly releases when Melog lifts their head to look towards the intrusion, draped over the side of the bed with Catra's form just barely visible on the other side of them. Scorpia was worried when Catra didnt show up this afternoon and Adora was terrified as soon as she got the call that something had happened to her. Laying in bed without telling anyone probably isnt good, but it isnt *ambushed by disoriented clones* or *run away again* bad.

Adora slips through the door and eases it shut behind her. It's possible Catra really is just tired. She could have taken a nap after breakfast and slept through when she was supposed to head out.

Melog kind of rules that out though when they slip off the bed and take a defensive stance the moment Adora begins to cross the room. Adora freezes, not sure what to do as Melog stares her down. Their mane is still placid and they look more wary than angry, but Melog doesnt stand between her and Catra like this. Melog *knows* Adora

always wants to help her. When Catra tried to leave her back in the Whispering Woods, she told Adora later that Melog tried to stop her from doing it. Adora looks up towards Catra, still lying on her side and facing the wall, completely motionless.

"Catra?" Adora calls, soft and concerned. Catra's ear flicks – she's conscious at least then – but neither she nor Melog reacts. Melog stays in their defensive stance, one Adora has seen them take many times, but only when Catra was threatened or at least startled. She blinks down at them, lost and confused and *very, very* worried. "I just want to check on her, buddy," Adora assures, her voice low and hopefully placating. Melog still looks wary, but their stance softens a little; they don't drop it fully.

Adora takes a step forward again. Melog is watching her, but they don't stop her as she cautiously crosses the room and steps around them to reach the bed. She pauses beside it, hand lifted to reach for Catra but unsure what to do. She isn't hurt or sick, Melog would come *get* Adora if that was the case, but she also isn't sure if touching her is a good idea. Catra didn't say anything about having nightmares this morning, but one that she just can't shake is Adora's best guess for what's wrong. Almost on cue, Catra growls. To her surprise, that seems to deactivate Melog. They turn around, nosing at Adora's hip and looking up at her sorrowfully.

That's something more normal for Adora to latch onto, and it gives her hope. Melog is worried about Catra and wants Adora to help, unusual defensiveness aside. Maybe they were just making sure Adora didn't approach too fast. Adora takes a deep breath and cautiously pets down Catra's arm. Catra curls in on herself a little and her growl rises, but she doesn't do anything more and Melog doesn't react except to hang their head over the edge of the bed and mew softly. Adora has heard Catra growl a *lot*, but since the end of the war, her growls have been brief, sounds of irritation or mostly-toothless warnings. This is a *threat* – one Adora isn't afraid of directly, but the cause of it worries her.

"What's wrong?" Adora asks, her voice as gentle as she can make it with her current anxiety. It's getting kind of hard for Adora to breathe. She's *scared*, and she knows Catra can tell. She can always tell when Adora is panicking, and the tip of her tail is twitching against the mattress. At this point, Adora can't tell anxiety from irritation, especially not when Melog makes a growl-like sound too but nuzzles against her hip as they do it. The point of contact makes her feel a little better, at least.

"Scorpia's really worried. She called to make sure you hadn't gotten hurt," there's a moment of silence, "or run away," Adora adds in a whisper. Scorpia didn't say anything about that, and maybe she wasn't even thinking it, but Adora definitely was. She was relieved when she first saw Catra, but she's approaching the levels of panic she was at on the way over here again. She could try to fool herself that there was an innocent explanation for the walk. She can't do that now.

"Are you hurt? Catra, I want to help," Adora all but begs. She wants to just turn Catra over and *see*, but as unafraid as she is of Catra's claws, there's something in the air—Catra's growl—that tells her Catra might actually swipe them at her if she tries. Adora can deal with that, but she doesn't think Catra can. It would only make whatever this is worse. Besides, she knows now that she was kind of shit at listening to Catra before and she's trying to do better. That growl makes it clear Catra doesn't want to be touched.

"No. Leave," Catra grinds out in the middle of her growl. Adora draws in a breath, relief hitting her lungs finally hearing Catra's voice, but it isn't nearly strong enough to calm her. It's also joined by a spark of annoyance that she hates herself for feeling, but Catra's worrying her and she's trying to *help*. She sighs, tilting her head back to stare up at the ceiling as if it will have answers on what she should do—or what's even *happening*—written on it.

"You know I can't, not when you're like this and I don't know why," Adora responds, looking back down and squeezing lightly at Catra's upper arm. Catra jerks her shoulder forward, curling in on herself

and pulling away from Adora's touch. Adora's throat tightens as her hand hangs in the empty air, her fingers flexing against nothing. Melog releases another sound, growly and sad, as they nuzzle Adora's side. Then they pull away and haul themselves up onto the bed, laying down beside Catra – though more towards the foot of the bed, not really getting between Adora and Catra. They place their head on top of the blankets and blink at her.

Adora's an idiot, and she takes that as an invitation, sitting down on the edge of the bed as well. Catra's growl *rattles*, upgrading to a snarl. Adora can just barely see her lip curl past her hair. If she still had her mane, she wouldn't be able to get even a glimpse at the side of her face. Adora doesn't know what to do. Catra hasn't acted like this with her since... well, since they rescued her. The closest was those first few days when she was still struggling to tell what was real or not.

"I'm a bad person. I'm going to hurt you," Catra grits out. Adora stares at her, some of the anxiety forgotten in favor of pure frustration.

"No, you aren't-" she starts to say, but Catra snarls again and finally *turns*, half sitting up to show Adora her curled lip and fangs. Her eyes are a bit wild with anxiety.

"I'm going to hurt you, so don't *make me*," she snaps back. Adora pulls back, an instinctual reaction to someone whirling on her, but Catra flinches like Adora was the one who lashed out, recoiling with panic in her eyes. Her ears pin back to her head. Adora wants to pull her into her arms and hug her, but Catra just flinched back from her. A few weeks ago, she might have tried it anyway, but she knows that would just make things worse. Melog nuzzles against Catra's side, trying to comfort her as they both just stare at each other.

"Don't let me. Please, just leave," Catra finally whispers, turning her face away again and shrinking in on herself. Adora struggles where she sits, feeling useless. She wants to help and she doesn't know

how or if she even *can*. She still doesn't know what is going on, but Catra isn't – physically – hurt.

It's probably a bad day. A very bad day. Regression, the thing they're both terrified of, both for themselves and the other. Adora swallows, squeezing her eyes shut and willing herself to just know what the right thing to do is, but she doesn't. She still doesn't know what is wrong, really, and that makes it hard to fix.

She knows now that Catra always hated how she would try to fix things, though.

"The only way you're going to hurt me is by leaving-" Catra actually scoffs, which somehow makes Adora feel better, because she's at least not so panicked, or angry, or whatever is happening here, that she can't manage derision anymore, "-but I don't want to hurt you either. So," Adora draws in a deep breath, "if you can tell me what's going on, I'll go. Because I want to listen to you, but I'm scared that things will get worse if I leave. If- if you just can't do it today, then we'll manage. But I don't want to lose you to yourself again."

This is *hard* for her. Respecting her girlfriend's wishes shouldn't be so hard, but how is she supposed to leave someone she loves so obviously in pain? She knows she's saying the wrong thing, guilt-tripping or something, but it's how she's feeling and she's supposed to be communicating that – and *feeling* rather than burying it – now. She doesn't know what the right thing to say is any more than she knows the right thing to do, but from what they've talked about since the war, half their problems during it seem to have come from Catra being too prideful, too sure it was too late, and just too deep in to look up. Adora isn't going to leave her to bury herself again.

Catra tightens herself into a ball, curling away from Adora. Adora's heart hammers as she waits. After a moment, she takes a risk on reaching out again, only this time she moves to pet Melog. Melog leans into the touch, but Catra gives no reaction. Normally Catra likes when Melog gets pet almost as much as herself, the positive feedback filtering through the bond. Not reacting might be good

though – at least she isn't growling again. Adora doesn't know if Catra is going to speak, and she doesn't know what she is going to do if she doesn't, but eventually Catra tightens in on herself further and finally opens her mouth to do something other than growl again.

"I woke up angry today . I'm going to lash out if I have to deal with anyone. But I don't want to, so just... stay away . Until I'm better again. Don't make me talk or do princess bullshit. This *isn't helping*," Catra grinds out. Adora winces, but she nods and finds it slightly easier to breathe with an answer at least. She spends a second just trying to relax her throat as she thinks that over . She remembers Catra's quiet reluctance and the hunch in her shoulders this morning as she told her it was time to get up. She told herself Catra was tired, but in retrospect, she was bristly and trying not to be.

This goes beyond *touchy*, but Catra is trying not to take it out on someone. She's being responsible in a way, caring for other people even if it's self-isolating. It' s definitely not healthy, but it's her trying *so damn hard* it adds an edge of the good kind of hurt to Adora's chest. This isn't like back on Dryla, where she shut herself away so she didn't have to face them. At least, it doesn't sound like it. She can't really ask more to know for sure – she has pushed Catra too far enough times at this point that she's starting to realize where her line is.

The line was when Melog stood between them back at the door, but at least she let Adora get some kind of answer. If she had shut her down completely, this definitely would have turned into a fight. Catra doesn't need that right now . Adora loves her so much and she wishes she could just take that painful anger out of her chest, but she knows it doesn't work like that. She has felt that anger herself, she just usually wants to turn it inwards. Once or twice, she has lashed out with it, putting a fist through the wall or yelling and blaming when something has gone terribly wrong and she can't keep it from boiling over, but the cruel edge to it is always aimed at herself.

She thinks that might hurt less than Catra's version of this feeling. This version she turns outwards and then hurts even worse when she wields the anger like a weapon against whoever is in the wrong place, at the wrong time. If Catra didn't feel guilt, she wouldn't be in a state like *this*. Adora still isn't sure why Melog was trying to keep her away when they're usually better at recognizing what the healthy thing for Catra to do is, but maybe they're at a loss the same way Adora is. Adora doesn't know *what* she can do other than give Catra the space she asked for.

One day, they will both be in a place where there's a better option, but it's not right now. She'll ask Perfuma about coping techniques for this kind of thing – if they exist – as soon as she gets the chance, but for today they both just have to do their best. Adora can't do the wrong thing now, not when Catra is already struggling with what she thinks is the right one. Adora *really* doesn't agree that hiding herself away is the way to deal with this, but she also doesn't know what a better option would be. Catra clearly doesn't want to be around people right now.

"Okay. I'll tell Scorpia that you're okay but you can't come out today," Adora says, her voice low and steady, trying not to aggravate. Catra doesn't reply, or even give an indication that she has heard her. Adora wants to do something, to soothe and help and assure, but instead she forces herself to stand. She watches Catra's ear swivel to listen to her, but other than that Catra doesn't move.

"I love you. I'll check-in later. You won't have to talk if you don't want to, and I'll try not to be annoying, but I'm not abandoning you either," she tells her. Catra's ears shift to pin against her head now, but she doesn't say anything. Adora wasn't expecting her to, but she gives her a few moments to reply just in case before she starts walking away. It's also just hard for her to take that first step away when she knows Catra is feeling so torn up inside. As she steps back, Melog crawls a little closer to cuddle up with Catra. It loosens something tight in her chest, still screwed too far but at least letting a little pressure release now.

"Thank you for staying with her . Take care of her," she tells Melog now, who replies with a blink and a low *mrr*. Adora finally forces herself to turn and leave the room, closing the door as softly as she can behind her. She just stands on the other side of it for a long moment before she forces herself to turn away and start making her way down the hall. Her chest is a knot of anxiety . Catra's- she's *okay*, but she isn't good.

Okay is enough. Okay gets them through the bad days. Making this a habit could end up worse than if Catra just lashed out and released it, but they'll figure something else out. It's just for today . Everything will be okay.

As Adora utterly fails to assure herself, she realizes that she isn't going to be able to make herself go far.

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Everything inside of Catra is twisted up and knotted, inflamed and angry. She wishes she had been plagued by nightmares last night, because as dumb as it is to be weakened by memories, it's better than just *being weak*. Instead she woke up angry and it didn't even have anything to do with Adora's absence. That was a *relief*, really; knowing she wasn't at risk of lashing out and hurting Adora first thing in the morning helped some. She can't lose her again, but sometimes it's hard not to fall back on the old pattern of believing that Adora left her – not the Horde, her , there isn't room for those to be distinct – because she wasn't enough and eventually Adora's going to realize that she still isn't now .

Insecurities whisper in her mind, telling her Adora and all their friends still hate her or if they don't yet they soon *will*. She knows better, kind of, but on days like today her heart doesn't and the internal conflict pushes her natural inclination towards defensive

anger too far. Anger is safe, far more familiar than the comfort of Bright Moon. She tried to swallow it down by the time Adora came back from her run, but irritation was itching at her fur. She bit her tongue all through breakfast, almost snapping when Glimmer's laughing grated at her ears, her mind turning it mocking. Every interaction took a hard edge to it, and the words on her tongue were ready to match it.

She can't deal with people today and she can't be nice. All she can do is hide. She won't hurt them, she *can't*. Adora sees the good in her as long as she is willing to try, so she has to do what she can. She worried what would happen if Adora eventually noticed and came to find her. Every moment Adora was in the room she was as scared she would snap at her girlfriend as she was angry at Adora for prying, and for phrasing it in a way that *blamed* Catra when really, it isn't her fault she's like this – except it is, and she still struggles with the truth that she has hurt herself as much as she has been hurt. Melog did their best to buffer them, but how is anyone supposed to stop Catra from being herself?

This isn't her, Melog reminds her right on cue, trying to soothe her. In some ways, it's working. She hasn't scratched anything up, at least, and even if she almost cried after Adora left, she *didn't*. She didn't ruin anything between them, at least she thinks, and Adora is trying to be understanding. More understanding than she was before or during the war, at least. They're both working on growing, but at the moment, growing looks like *this* for Catra, knowing that any other option is going to result in her doing or saying something cruel.

Melog, for all that they are allowing her to isolate, still isn't going to let her wallow. They're doing a remarkable job of cutting her off from her self-loathing spirals, even if a new one starts again just as fast as Melog can cut them off. They cuddle her, reminding her that she is loved and that *they* love her even knowing what the inside of her head is like. It feels good to hug them, cuddling an unjudgmental presence, but Melog is still an *opinionated* one and they don't want her to stay curled up in the bed. In truth, she doesn't either, but the

softness is a form of comfort even if she is slowly transitioning from feeling angry and volatile to limp and worthless.

That—probably—should be an improvement. She doesn't really know. It's less likely to hurt other people, but it feels worse. That might just be because anger is so familiar and even useful if channeled correctly. Melog doesn't have an answer for her, but they aren't going to let her stay here, so maybe that's answer enough. She's drained from all the emotional turmoil. She lets Melog bully her out of bed, nudging her pointedly toward the closest source of fresh air.

However Melog feels about it, Catra isn't leaving the room, but she settles on the lounge they've left near the entrance onto big, dumb balcony because she likes to lay on it in the sun and have Adora play with her hair even while Adora complains about the warmth. It wouldn't be a problem if Adora didn't insist on wearing a jacket all the time, but even when she complains she still stays and cuddles Catra. It could be because of the memories as much as it could be from the fresh air, but Catra feels a bit better sitting there.

Something about the sun makes it easier to breathe, relaxing her body and letting her mind quiet down. The dark thoughts turn to whispers, though they are still interrupted by the occasional shout that has her teeth setting on edge as she tries to *forget* that horrible thing she just thought.

Adora said she would be back. Catra was both hoping she was lying and desperately looking forward to it. It could be okay—or Adora could get on her last nerve. It doesn't feel like Adora takes long after Catra moves to the balcony to come back, but maybe her head is just so full of insecurities that she can't keep track of time anymore. She could have been wallowing in the bed longer than she thought, too. That might explain why Melog was so insistent she get out of it. Time hasn't felt very consequential since she first decided to hide away for the day. It was like that up on Prime's ship too, and it shows where she is mentally that she's drawing those parallels.

Catra is too preoccupied to be vigilant of her surroundings, but Melog gently muscles their way into her thoughts to inform her that Adora is outside the door. For a moment, Catra thinks Melog sensed her magic –they're getting better at doing that now , as they adjust to living in a world full of magic and life again –but then they add that she brought food. t' s possible they just smelled it. Catra doesnt detect it, but she has her face towards the sky and Adora is downwind –and through a wall.

t' s lunchtime, probably. t' s been a while since breakfast at least, so it would make sense, and it would give Adora an excuse to come back and check on her. Catra could tell how hard it was for her to leave. She thinks it's part of why she felt able to move to the lounge. The sun is doing the rest of the work, but having Adora try to understand and still tell her she loves her –still assure her that she' s there for her even if she's rotten on the inside –helped with her insecurities some.

t takes several moments after Melog informs her Adora is outside for Adora to make any attempt to enter or communicate that fact for herself.

"Catra? Can I come in? I brought lunch," Adora calls, her voice muffled. Catra lolls her head back, face turned toward the sun and her eyes closed. She thinks she would be at least ten percent better as a person if they had sunshine like this back in the Fright Zone. And clear air. The smog would have ruined it even if it didnt darken the sky, but everything feels a bit better under the warmth of the sun. At least right now. In an hour it might make her hot and irritated.

"Y eah," Catra calls back, raising her voice enough to be heard and not much more. She doesnt attempt to turn her head to watch Adora enter, but Adora doesnt *attempt to enter* either. There's a long moment of silence.

"Um, so, I maybe didnt plan ahead and my hands are full," Adora calls back, a tinge of embarrassment to her voice. Catra snorts, her tail flicking in silent signal that Melog follows immediately, hauling

themselves up and crossing over to the door. Catra swivels her ears back to listen as they open the door, but she still doesn't move. She feels...okay, right here, so she isn't leaving. *Okay* might as well be a miracle given how she woke up.

This is still nowhere near any of her previous lows, though, and that's weirdly comforting. It's uncomfortable and bad, sure, but if she had any duties that were in Bright Moon and didn't require interaction with people, she could probably get it done with only some irritation. Traveling, coordinating people, and deciding the future construction of a kingdom is beyond her, but she could do paperwork alone in Glimmer's office if she asked her to. She's glad she doesn't have to, but her realizations have her slowly feeling a bit better as Adora enters the room and walks close enough for the scent of food to reach Catra.

She's hungry. She didn't *know* she was hungry, but she definitely is. She tilts her head back, opening her eyes and craning her head over the back of the lounge to watch Adora approach upside down. Even from this angle, her smile is bright and hopeful. Melog is still lingering back over by the door, head stuck out in the hallway, but Catra isn't paying attention to them when Adora is carrying a large tray of food. No wonder she couldn't open the door. Catra lets her chin fall forward as Adora rounds the side of the lounge and sits on its end with unearned caution. When Catra's only reaction is to sit up properly and focus on the food, however, Adora straightens her back with new confidence and sets the tray down in between them.

"I didn't make any of it, so don't worry, it should be good," Adora tells her with a lopsided smile. Catra snorts, reaching out to grab the plate with fish—she doesn't know which one it is, but she recognizes fish now and always makes a beeline for it, so she can't help but wonder if Adora specifically requested it for her—from the selection. The tray bears a few plates, which still seems like an unbelievable amount of food to regularly eat to her, but it's fairly standard for the castle kitchens. Usually spreads like this are reserved for dinner, but it isn't just for Catra.

There's a bowl of those weird nut things on the side that Adora likes and Catra cant eat because they hurt her stomach. There' s also one of the large, curved dishes Melog eats out of taking up a fourth of the tray. Catra mentally reaches out to them as she takes her first bite, calling them back. She *has* to call them back, because they wandered out the door, investigating something. She frowns, turning her head to watch them pad back towards the lounge. She didnt expect them to go further than ten feet from her today .

Oh. Oh, Melog saw the door to Bow' s room down the hall is open and went to see if he was there. From the scent, Adora has been in there this whole time, likely with the door open and keeping an eye out for movement in the hall. She dragged his small writing desk to be just within the doorway . As they pad back, Melog shows her the maps Adora left scattered across it when she went to get food. Catra turns her head to look at Adora and is surprised to find her smile gone, watching her with a hint of nerves. Unless she has somehow been tracking Melog's movements, she shouldnt know that *Catra* knows, but- right, Catra's frowning and that's enough to upset her girlfriend.

"W orried Iwas gonna run?" Catra says, a weak joke, but she isnt up to much more. f she tries to really banter , her humor might take an unpleasant edge to it, falling back into the familiar patterns of what passed for socialization in the Horde. Adora, to her surprise, looks a bit embarrassed, glancing back towards the door to spot Melog walking back in. Catra raises a brow at her.

"Maybe a little. Mostly Iwanted to be here if anything happened. f you decided being around people was better , then Ididnt want you to have to walk far or deal with anyone you werent comfortable with," Adora says, sheepish. Catra snorts as she takes another bite. *People*, right. The list of *people* she would want to comfort her when she's like this would pretty much just be Adora and Glimmer , maybe Bow , and only Entrapta or Scorpia when her emotions are in the best place they can be and still warrant this. Her friends can be a lot. Sometimes that's what she needs, though.

"Does Bow know?" she asks as she keeps eating. Adora relaxes enough to pick up one of the absurdly large nuts – apparently they're naturally packed with the kind of nutrients they used to get out of ration bars, only they actually taste edible if you can stomach them – and pops one into her mouth.

"I sent his tracker pad a message. Not my fault if he doesn't check it," she says with a shrug, flashing Catra a smile. There's still an edge of uncertainty to her, almost like she expects Catra to kick her out, but she's a lot more relaxed than she was when she came to find Catra earlier. That's probably because Catra is too, though. Catra knew seeing her upset would also upset Adora, but not as badly as Catra picking a fight with her new friends would, probably.

She's maybe too drained to pick a fight now. She's still- she isn't doing *well*, but it's the tolerable kind of insecure, the kind she would have found to be a relief back during the dark days of the war, and it doesn't warrant getting in a fight just to deal with. Or maybe being angry is just more work than she remembers. It's an improvement, anyway. She thinks Adora… *not* staying in Bow's room might be okay, but she doesn't say what she's thinking, instead nodding quietly and continuing to eat. Adora doesn't try to press it, seeming happy to do the same beside her. Lunch is, if nothing else, an opportunity to see.

Melog says she should ask. That she shouldn't wallow, and that being alone isn't a solution. That what has helped has been *them* and Adora could help too. Even they agree conversation might be a bad idea – something it is fine for Adora to say most days might catch under Catra's armor today and leave her raw and angry – but since Adora appeared before the door, Catra has gone from relatively lifeless and vaguely irritated to anxious but *wanting*. Wanting – with the chance of having – feels so much better than just hurting.

She doesn't say anything until they finish eating, still. She waits for it to suddenly turn bad, for something as simple as Adora crunching on the nuts to start grating on her sensitive hearing and *nerves*, but it

doesn't. Adora's a loud eater, but she's also a loud snorer, and a loud everything else, really. Catra is used to it. It's *Adora*, so it kind of makes her heart warm, sometimes. Paying attention, though, she notices the frequency of Adora's crunches is going down. A glance between the dishes on the tray reveals Adora is – maybe for the first time in her life – *pacing herself*, dragging out the speed at which she picks up the nuts and eats them.

She has to be doing it so she doesn't finish before Catra. Adora loves these things, and when Catra looks up Adora conspicuously looks away and shoves another one in her mouth far too fast – much closer to the speed at which she usually eats. Catra feels a warm spark in her chest, which might as well be a bonfire compared to the cold she has been dealing with. After she finishes chewing her own bite, she clears her throat a little. Despite pretending she wasn't paying attention just seconds earlier, Adora's eyes snap to her.

"Is that your lunch?" Catra asks, glancing down at the mostly empty bowl of nuts. Her own plate is mostly empty too. Melog's shoulder is bumping into her as they eat standing beside the lounge, their head craned over Catra's knee to reach the tray, but despite their less-ideal spot and how they're getting in her way, they're about halfway done too.

"Huh?" Adora glances down at the bowl, and then the nut in her hand, as if she has never seen them before, "Yeah. Calorically dense," she answers brightly, meeting Catra's eyes again. She is *not* thinking about calories or nutrition. Catra snorts.

"You barely know what that means," she replies, because even she has only learned the basics since coming to Bright Moon and she knows for a fact Adora isn't more versed in pretty much any aspect of food except *eating it* than she is. Adora doesn't seem bothered. She smiles like the sun in response.

"I know it's healthy and better than ration bars," she replies, like that's all the criteria food has to meet. To her, it probably is. Catra looks at her knowing there's too much love in her eyes for such a

simple statement, but as much as Adora overcomplicates *many* things, others are just straightforward with her. Things that should be conflicting and hard—loving Catra, for one—just become easy for her because she *says so*. She says Catra is a good person and then waits for Catra to prove it. Well, Catra promised she would try first, but that was weeks ago and Adora still has no doubts. Catra wasn't exactly nice to her this morning, even if it was nothing like her old cruelty, and Adora is still willing to just wait and smile at her like it's all going to be okay.

Of course it's going to be okay for Adora. For Adora, she spent the entire war waiting for Catra to just see the light and join the Rebellion—that easy. Catra thought she would die long before that would be a possible option, much less one she would go through with. The things that are hardest for Catra are often the ones that come to Adora naturally. Maybe that's balance. Maybe that's why Catra, despite always loving her, nurtured a quiet bitterness over Adora's accomplishments for years that she did her best to ignore. It doesn't really matter: right now she's grateful for Adora's ability to just *accept*.

"You don't have to go back to wrecking Bow's room," Catra says finally, leaning back from the tray to give Melog unhindered access to it.

"I'm not wrecking it!" Adora protests immediately, clearly in the middle of processing because Catra watches a smile spark to life at the end of her words. Despite her protests, it's just as bright as the last one when it finishes spreading over her face. Catra raises a brow.

"Melog showed me what you did to his desk," she returns. Adora should not be this excited over Catra inviting her back to the room—for one, they could still get in a fight, and for another, Adora has her own work to do and not much else for entertainment—but either that hasn't occurred to Adora yet or she's still excited because she only breaks her smile to throw Catra an indignant look. It's performative. She still looks far too happy around the pout

"Then you know I was just rearranging it," she replies. Catra coughs something that might be a laugh and looks away, because all those old, angry, insecure instincts are telling her not to show weakness – emotion – in front of someone right now . Adora was always the person she felt the safest doing it with regardless, but it's a small, easy defensive instinct to give in to that doesn't harm anything. If she suppresses stuff like that on top of the urges that would leave clawmarks in the castle walls, she's far more likely to break.

"If Sparkles did that to our room I would kick her out of her own castle," Catra replies. She doesn't think anyone else in the castle has the same issues she does, but if anyone came into one of the few places she considers hers and *safe*, especially if they started moving things around, she would be furious. Actually, she would be *scared*, and a pointless fear response like that would trigger anger. That's how she got where she is right now, insecure when you get down to the root of it, and irritated as a result.

"She won't mind," Adora returns, which is probably true. Catra sniffs.

"Better if it's all in place when he gets back anyway," she says. In the corner of her eye, she can see Adora smiling again. Still. Whatever. It isn't a grin or anything, and Adora is *hovering* a little in a way that seems hesitant, but the smile gives Catra at least some signal that Adora isn't protesting because she doesn't actually want to come in. Catra heaves a sigh.

"I still don't want to talk. And I might kick you out if I feel like I might start a fight. But you can stay for now if you want," she says, her tone gruff as she shrugs. Melog pauses in the middle of finishing their food to mew loudly at her. She flicks an ear and doesn't otherwise acknowledge their message. She definitely isn't *translating* it.

Yes, okay, she's kind of thinking that a make out might solve at least twenty of her thirty different emotional issues right now, but that's mostly because it would be a mix of attention – affection, love, whatever, irrelevant – and a safe way to work out her aggression a

little. They've always come close to grappling in bed at times, and while it might help, it also could turn *bad*. It never has, but that doesn't stop her being afraid of going too far or having a flashback. She isn't risking it today – at least not right now.

Melog thinks she should invite Adora to at least hug her or something, but inviting her into the room is about as far across the line as she is willing to push herself right now. She's so lucky no one else can understand them. They would expose her constantly. They already do it enough just from their behavior and shifting mane.

"Ok. I can just go over maps at the desk. I can do that pretty much anywhere," Adora assures her. Yeah, her voice is just a little too positive for Catra right now, but it isn't *too* annoying, especially knowing that she's happy for the opportunity to spend time with Catra. That thought alone makes her feel better in much the same way the "sunshine" did. She feels her lips twitch and has to remind herself that there's no reason for her to fight her smile. She still doesn't grin like Adora or anything, but she's sure Adora can see the flicker across her face.

She watches Adora reach over in her periphery, holding her hand out across the tray. Adora stops short of touching her, and after a moment of ignoring her – waiting – Catra flicks her ears and looks down. Adora is definitely holding her hand out for Catra to hold. Catra narrows her eyes at the hand, but she reluctantly reaches out and takes it. Adora beams across at her while Catra refuses to look up from their hands. That backfires when Adora tugs gently on her hand, lifting it as she leans down to kiss the back of Catra's hand softly. Catra feels her face heat as Adora looks up at her, eyes stupidly big and endearing from how she is still bent to kiss her hand.

"You sure?" she asks, breath ghosting across Catra's skin and sending a shiver through her. That kind of intimacy hits different right now, something she desperately craves and almost fears. The craving is winning out, though. She feels her tail lash back and forth behind her as she nods, and then spots the ghost of a smirk

creeping up Adora's face, so she quickly rolls her eyes and looks away. Aloof and unaffected, definitely not flustered by a *hand kiss*.

"Yeah, just don't be annoying," she replies. She doesn't like how her voice sounds, like how she always talked – always *was* – back during the war. Or maybe it's just her usual attitude and she's sensitive to it given her current mood. She *hates* backsliding. Yesterday was so good, so *fun*, and today her own head is tormenting her. She can't decide if she's grateful for Adora or annoyed at her, because Adora exists outside of her head and isn't affected by her bitter thought spirals. She just chuckles a laugh and straightens up like nothing's wrong – because it isn't, actually – still holding Catra's hand.

"Hm, that's a pretty big ask," she muses, because she's an idiot and Catra loves kissing her. Well, not *because* of that last thing, but it is a thought she's having right now. Melog is practically gloating, smug how right they were about Adora's presence, but Catra ignores them except to wap them once with her tail as they walk away to lay out by the swinging vines that have replaced Adora's old waterfall, done eating and confident now that Catra doesn't need them to stay so close.

"I know it is, but just shut up and you'll be fine," Catra returns. That terrible quality isn't in her voice anymore. It might be because she's smiling.

"That might be a bigger ask," Adora says. Catra can hear the smile in her voice too, and the words don't quite earn a chuckle, but she manages an amused hum. She finally turns to look at Adora again and sees Adora *smirking*, as if there's reason to be smug about her big mouth. Catra drops Adora's hand so she can reach across and cover Adora's mouth instead. Adora sends her a look of indignation mostly conveyed via exaggerated eyebrow movement. Catra manages to hold down her smile long enough to make direct and pointed eye contact with Adora so she can *watch* as Catra roll her eyes at her.

When their eyes meet again, Adora has given up on feigning offense and her eyes are sparkling, so blue and soft. Catra's breath hitches as she registers the world outside of this moment between them again. It isn't before of the sound of the breeze surprising her or anything like that – it's the realization that for a moment, Adora and her dumb antics made Catra forget everything that has been weighing her down today. It isn't magically gone, but it's a moment that was better than the high points from the entire rest of her morning.

Catra leans in closer, towards the eyes that definitely aren't *usually* this blue, but she doesn't think She-ra is at risk of coming out, Adora's just sparkling with magic like the fucking goddess she is. She watches Adora's eyes flick down to her lips as Catra slides her hand to the side, cupping Adora's cheek instead of covering her mouth. The moment Catra's hand is out of the way, she presses closer so their lips can meet.

It's a chaste kiss by their standards but it feels *good* even with the part of her mind that's upset by Adora's mere presence when she's in a mental place like this. For this moment, though, Adora isn't an embodiment of all the people who have left her behind and all her failures as a person that led to them doing so – Adora's just her girlfriend. Her sweet, stupid, magical girlfriend. Even back when Adora did leave her, she didn't go far, because she's right back under Catra's lips now and never really wanted to be anywhere else.

As much as it annoyed her at the time, Adora was right to say she could lose Catra to herself. Her life has been *shit*, but some of it could have been easier if it weren't for the dark trap her mind had fallen into. She could have left all that darkness behind, but it had found home in her heart until anything else felt terrifying. Just this morning she wanted Adora *gone*, all the light and happiness grating on her instincts as they shouts *fake, wrong, you'll lose it all eventually*.

Adora's kiss is as soft and sweet as always, every indication in it that she wants to keep kissing forever – she even said that, once. Twice.

A few times, actually. Adora raises her hand up and threads it through Catra's hair, holding her close but not trying to direct her, letting Catra stay in charge as she anchors herself. She sighs softly with obvious content when their lips part. Catra considers kissing her again, and she even considers just *staying* with their faces so close that her nose can nuzzle Adora's cheek, but in the end she pulls back and is rewarded with the beautiful, hazy look that is often in Adora's eyes when they first part after a long kiss.

It's a look far from the ground of Etheria, lost in something better than can be found in any physical location except the space right between two people. It makes Catra draw in a breath that feels too big for her chest as she settles back across from her. Adora blinks the looks away, sending a smile that Catra answers with a smirk too casual for all the thoughts and feelings going through her head.

She definitely wants Adora to stay.

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Adora sets up at their desk with her maps and tracker pad, making sure to put Bow's room back in order before she settles down to work again. In the back of her mind, she's aware of Catra's location in the room, but she isn't exactly doing much. At first she lounges on the bed a good distance away from Adora, but then she moves closer. When Adora looks up Catra settles at the vanity and sends her a glare with the clear message to mind her business.

The condition of her presence seems to be them mostly ignoring each other, but she's just glad that Catra isn't totally isolating herself – at least, as isolated as she can get with Melog at her side – anymore. Speaking of Melog, they lay down across Adora's feet as Catra sets to filing her claws, sharpening some and decidedly *dulling* others. Adora is happy enough with just having Catra around while

she works. They do this sometimes even when they're both in a great mood. It's good to just be near each other. Adora is decidedly worse at entertaining herself if she isn't given work to do, but Catra is more committed to being a nuisance and making Adora pay attention to her in general, so they both eventually crack when they're supposed to be doing something else.

Speaking of, despite Catra's insistence that she doesn't want to talk—or for Adora to even *look* at her apparently—she is definitely creeping closer, settling on a poof not far from Adora this time. She usually sits there while brushing her hair, but it doesn't seem like she's doing anything right now. Adora tries very hard not to smile as she marks her map. Checking her list on the side of the desk gives her a reason to turn her face away, at least, so she can make sure her expression doesn't betray how much attention she's paying to Catra. She personally thinks they *should* talk—Catra seemed so much better when they started poking around—but if she annoys Catra by pushing, Catra might make her leave, and she wants to at least be in the room with her.

She would probably only last twenty minutes of silence at best, even with work to focus on, but Catra breaks before she does. Not that she says anything, but she slips away from Adora's periphery and then reappears behind her, draping herself over the back of the chair so she can rub her cheek against the side of Adora's head. Adora releases a—pleasantly—surprised sound, reaching up to place her hand over Catra's arms that have looped around her shoulders from behind. Apparently that's too much acknowledgement for Catra, though, because she releases a displeased rumble—not quite a growl, but close—as she tucks her face against the side of Adora's head.

"I'll pay attention to you if that's what you want, you know," Adora points out, more amused than discouraged by Catra's moodiness. If this kind of thing bothered her, she wouldn't have made it far after the first time Catra bit her for no good reason. She chances turning her head so she can look up at Catra. Catra immediately hisses at

her and flees back to the bed as if caught –like Adora wouldnt notice Catra scent marking her until she looked at her. Adora raises an eyebrow at her girlfriend sulking in the bed again, her tail trailing over the side and twitching. She glances down at Melog, still draped over her feet. They blink back at her and then flick an ear, looking back towards the bed.

She doesnt know if that is an encouragement to follow or not, but when she stands Melog doesnt try to trap her via her feet, so they at least dont feel strongly about her staying away from Catra. Catra' s tail twitches faster as Adora approaches. Adora settles on the side of the bed and reaches for it. Catra almost sqeaks –she' s sure Catra would say she hissed, but that's definitely not what that sound was – and her tail lashes harder, but Adora manages to catch it and pet down its length even as it twitches in her hands. Catra grumbles, but it isnt the growl she was giving Adora when she came to the room for the first time. This feels more like Catra's usual act that she hates affection. She doesnt put it on that often anymore, but it has never bothered Adora, not when she knows how Catra really feels. She prefers when Catra loves her openly, soaking in it and giving it back happily, but she knows how hard that can be.

"I love you. Even when you're pissy ," Adora tells her with her voice dripping in fondness. Catra lets out an indignant sound, raising her head to glare at Adora over her shoulder.

"I am *not* pissy," she grumbles, which makes Adora want to laugh. Catra has spent all morning saying she's angry and she's embodying a mood swing right now, but she's sure Catra doesnt actually thinks she's the height of emotional stability right now. She's protesting to cover her genuine reaction. Adora suppresses her amusement down to a chuckle as she pets her tail.

"Y ou're a little pissy ," Melog drops their head in Adora' s lap in a blatant big for attention, apparently done waiting after following her over to the bed, "See, even Melog agrees," Adora says, reaching over to pet them too. She leaves one hand on Catra, but apparently that isnt enough because Catra makes the same af fronted sound

she did before and immediately sits up, flopping back so she can land in Adora's lap and nudge Melog out of the way with her shoulder. She glares up at Adora – *adorably*, Adora might add – as she does nothing but prove her point.

"They're just standing there," Catra counters. Melog immediately meows. Catra absorbs whatever they said with nothing but a flick of her ear, but Adora is fairly confident they just agreed with her even if she was stretching it when she first started talking. Still, she smiles to herself as she reaches down and frames Catra's face in her hands so she can scratch both ears at once.

"Standing in agreement. They told me," Adora bullshits. Catra snorts, and Adora is pretty sure she tries to roll her eyes, but they end up fluttering closed instead as Adora's fingers find just the right spot.

"I'm the – one with the psychic bond," Catra gets out, words just a *little* disrupted by a purr starting. Catra tries to warp it into a growl at the end, but instead it just kind of stutters in and out. Adora knows that the smirk she can't wipe off her face right now could make Catra competitive under normal circumstances, but she has her eyes closed, so it doesn't kick anything off, leaving only Catra's stuttery purr in the air that Adora hates to talk over, but she thinks talking – *especially* about stupid shit – is helping.

"Actually I can understand them too, we just didn't want to tell you so you wouldn't get jealous," Adora replies. She thinks Melog plays along, because they let out a smug mew. She and Melog *have* been bonding as they both feel out their magic post-Heart, but she's pretty sure no one is ever going to be able to truly understand them except Catra. Entrapta's running an experiment on it, actually. She has just been using her recorder and springing questions on Catra when Melog talks, so she might be missing something, but it seems like Melog uses the same sound to communicate different concepts, so the psychic component is likely crucial. Melog doesn't seem bothered by being limited to talking with Catra. Adora *does* understand them in some ways even without words. Again – she's pretty sure they're agreeing with her.

Catra turns her head to narrow her eyes at Melog and then looks back to Adora to scoff.

"You're both idiots," she says, which might as well be *I love you* in Catra-language. Adora smiles to herself as she shifts her hands to hold Catra's head still as she bends to press a kiss to her forehead. Knowing the mood she's in, Catra might duck away from a kiss just to be contrary, and with their current positions that would result in a headbutt. Catra pretends to retch when Adora kisses her instead, and then when Adora straightens up she makes a far more believable sound of indignation.

Adora loves her *so much*. She returns to scratching Catra's ears and she immediately quiets, letting her eyes fall closed again. The fight leaks out of her slowly, replaced with contentment as she melts in Adora's hands. As much as Catra being fussy makes her fond – it's so *Catra* that she loves it – she likes her like this more. She likes Catra liquid with content, purring off and on as she seems to lose herself in Adora's touch. At some point Catra's eyes flutter open and she tilts her head back into the touch to better direct Adora's touch, but she blushes when she sees the way Adora is looking at her and she closes her eyes again quickly.

For a few seconds. Then she can't resist, slitting her eyes open and watching Adora with hooded eyes, like she thinks it won't count if she looks at her through her lashes. It actually just makes Adora think about how beautiful she is and how much she wants to kiss her, but she doesn't try to bend down again for it. Catra is happy right now, and she deserves that after the morning she has had. She would keep doing this as long as Catra wants her to, but her hands are starting to cramp up. Still, she goes as long as she can, a little nervous to stop and ruin Catra's mood. When her scratches grow erratic, she finally smooths her hands to just frame Catra's head, her fingers buried in the soft fur on her ears.

Catra doesn't open her eyes right away. Her purr falls away, but she stays in Adora's lap instead of bolting to the other end of the room and pretending that she doesn't like her. Adora is content to sit in the

silence for at least a few minutes. Silence is bearable when she's looking at Catra's face.

Eventually, Melog turns away from them and pads out to the balcony. Adora is a little afraid that making any movement will break the spell, but she watches them go as much as she is able to without turning her head. They seem to be going all the way out to the part of the balcony completely blocked from view on the bed. She hopes that's a good sign. Sure, they still aren't leaving Catra alone, but they're confident enough in her state to wander a little further.

Several more moments pass before Catra's eyes slit open, finding Adora's gaze.

"Kiss me," she requests, voice a low whisper. Adora complies without hesitation.

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Adora kisses her soft, a whisper of the love that she needs. It's sweet, but not what she's craving. She told herself she didn't need any of this, but she was lying through her teeth. Once Adora was here, it got a lot harder to resist. She can't believe Adora came over to the bed after she hissed her, but she kind of can, because Adora never learned not to approach a growling cat. She was still kind of expecting her to give up on her – or *listen* to her and leave her alone – but Adora came over, and she even made Catra laugh, though she did her best to suppress it.

When she tilts her head back, demanding, Adora kisses her properly, understanding her just like she did earlier. She knows the position has to be uncomfortable for Adora because it's uncomfortable for *her* and she's definitely the one better situated, but she's pretty sure Adora plans to keep going until she physically can't anymore, like

with the ear scratches. Catra decides to go easy on her and sits up. It's awkward because she insists on kissing Adora the whole time so they don't have to look at each other and acknowledge that Catra has broken as easily as a record in any combat simulation she or Adora attempted, but she manages to get situated straddling Adora's lap.

It's not really where she wants to be, and Adora gets that message with just a few tugs towards the side on her jacket collar. Her hands come up, one between Catra's shoulder blades and the other on her lower back, so she can support Catra as she turns them and leans down, letting her crawl over Catra as she leans back onto the mattress.

She wants Adora on her, wanting her, loving her, assuring her. She's so stupid. She doesn't know why she tried to silence the voices in her head on her own when Adora could do it so easily with her lips. It was about self-reliance, or something – yeah, right, it was all because of the fear that Adora *couldn't*, or worse, wouldn't want to try. But she is, reaching up to cup Catra's cheek and cradling her like she can't get enough of kissing her. There's an energy running through Adora, a happiness that Catra doesn't need to guess the source of.

"I love you," Adora manages to murmur in the moment between kisses, before Catra captures her again. Adora doesn't seem bothered by her neediness, nor the fact that she isn't saying it back. It isn't that she doesn't want to, kissing is just more important right now. She thought she might need a make out to work this *thing* out of her system, but while she wasn't exactly wrong, it wasn't really about the kissing. What she actually needed was affection, *love*, assurance. She just wasn't ready for it yet – today, or back at the start of the war, not after it being forbidden for their entire childhoods – and tried to kid herself she didn't need it.

She gives Adora a lot of grief for being a bit of an airhead sometimes, but Catra really is *stupid*. She could have just been having this. Maybe she couldn't have – maybe she was too pissy for

even this beautiful, incredible thing then – but she certainly could have had it a bit sooner if she had pulled her head out of her ass. She's so lucky none of that bothers Adora. She was willing to stay and wait until Catra was ready, and she even knew her well enough to push through her play at indifference. Maybe most importantly, she left Catra alone earlier when she really needed it.

It's everything she needed from Adora. Her hands are everywhere she needs them to be, one curling into her hair as Adora's free arm comes up to support her, letting Catra know that she is prepared to be there for long enough that her core could get tired – and that's a *long* time for Adora. Catra purrs a little into the next kiss, and only huffs instead of complaining outright when Adora breaks the kiss to giggle at her before sealing their lips together again.

Melog, rudely, butts into her mind for a moment for a gloating *I told you so* before they go back to "minding their business" – yeah right – out on the balcony. They left to give them privacy while they had the long-overdue make out and cuddle that Catra needed, but of course they have to be smug about it. They're a cat, after all. Smug is kind of their thing. Catra ignores it as she wriggles down into a better position on the mattress, tail hitting both of their legs as it sweeps back and forth, but she's content and doesn't care.

The insecurities will probably still be there, quiet but present, when their lips part, but they really have no place when Adora is kissing her. If they have to make out all afternoon, so be it. More likely they'll do this for a while and then cuddle together until something demands their attention. If they're really lucky, they'll be able to stay like this until dinner. Catra would be annoyed if they get interrupted, but she thinks she could handle it now. It took her half the day and a little attention from Adora to calm down, but she's feeling better. Not perfect – certainly not "normal" – but better.

She knows the moral should be that she shouldn't try to deal with these things on her own – that's what Adora will probably say later tonight, when she thinks Catra isn't likely to swipe at her for it – but Melog is the one in her head, and even they knew that Adora being

around this morning wouldnt have helped. There’ s a base level of not *freaking the fuck out* that she needs to reach before anyone else’s presence will help. She did cling on to the instinct to be alone longer than she needed to, though, and she still made Adora work for it even after that, hissing at her the way she did.

Maybe shell be better next time. Maybe she wont. Maybe she will be eventually, if she’s lucky. She’s pretty sure Adora is going to be there with her again either way, coaxing her back to a good place, and that thought alone is proof of how far she has come since this morning. She decides that she will take that as her win for today. She didnt do something nice, or make an apology , or try to fix something she broke during the war, but she didnt hurt anyone today either and she’s making her way back towards somewhere good.

Actually, she’s in Adora’s arms. She’s already in the best place she could be.

End Notes

The vine-waterfall thing is a deep cut Iwas reminded of kind of recently lol

Okay now time for That One Project (◡‿◡✿)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!